

A WEALTH OF CUISINE FOR THE CURIOUS JAPAN-BOUND TRAVELER

Images of raw fish, sticky rice and flavored noodles pop into the head of most people planning their trip to Japan. Not so for the seasoned resident of this amazing nation. Residents in Japan hail from every country imaginable, so the choice of cuisine is endless. Here are a few places recommended for a break from “Washoku” Japanese Food.

MIDDLE EASTERN: MY LEBANON

Almost invisible from the road and about 10 minutes walk from Ebisu station, "My Lebanon" is the ultimate in Middle Eastern food in Tokyo. The complete course of Hummus, Baba Ganouge, Tabouli salad, hot appetizers and a main course of lovely shredded chicken with magnificent garlic sauce is so delicious, you could actually miss the beautiful belly dancer who performs on Friday nights. The ambiance of the restaurant is purely "Lebanon" and the staff assists you carefully in perfect English. I have never seen my children so quiet as they reveled in the deep and intricate flavor of the food, the soft pita bread and the delightful desert. Lebanese beer and wine are also available. (<http://www.mylebanonjp.com/press.htm>)

MEXICAN: LA SALSA, WORLD PORTERS, YOKOHAMA

Out in Yokohama for a day? Landmark Tower is a must. As the tallest building in Japan (273 meters), it features an amazing lookout gallery. The elevator to the 69th floor is one of the fastest in the world (just 40 seconds) and rumor has it that the ride is so smooth you can place a coin standing on the floor and it would not fall over during the ride. Wow! Now, that is Japanese technology at its best. After a glimpse of majestic Mount Fuji from this towering height, you might be in the mood for some great Mexican cuisine. Just nearby in the World Porters shopping plaza on the 5th floor is a popular lunch joint known as "La Salsa". Here you can get an extensive buffet lunch decked out with freshly made tortillas, tacos and every kind of Mexican chili sauce you can imagine. (<http://www.yim.co.jp/shop/5f021.html>)

SOUTH INDIAN: DHABA INDIA

<http://search.japantimes.co.jp/cgi-bin/fg20040206rs.html>

Well, how about one evening you feel the craving for some Dosa? What to do in this Oriental paradise? Yes, you head down to Dhaba India which is located about 5 minutes walk from the Yesu exit at Tokyo station. The light blue floors and walls, the bright paint and the happy smiles are all purely South Indian. Featuring food from Kerala, Madras and other areas of South India, this is a haven for many of the short to extended stay Indian visitors working in Tokyo. They even offer one meal served on a nice green leaf and provide excellent Basmati rice imported directly from India. This is an excellent place to take Japanese customers who are interested in trying delicious Indian fare. (<http://search.japantimes.co.jp/cgi-bin/fg20040206rs.html>)

AMERICAN

Last but not least, for American food, the choice is easy. Like other countries, Japan's Hard Rock Cafes offer the best American cuisine. My favorite is the Hard Rock Café Yokohama. Located in the trendy Queen's Tower in the Minato Mirai area just next to Sakuragicho station, the manager revamped the menu about two years ago and everything from the fajita selection to the salads and desserts are simply delicious. The veggie burger combines so many flavours, you won't know what you are eating, only that it is superb! The Hard Rock Cafes are perfect for birthday parties as well. The DJ announces the birthday, plays a great rock-n-roll birthday song and then staff gather around your table to sing. Often the entire restaurant joins in and the whole affair ends with a hearty applause. (<http://www.asiarooms.com/travel-guide/japan/yokohama/what-where-to-eat/american-restaurants-in-yokohama/hard-rock-cafe.-yokohama.html>)

More and more, Japan is becoming the world's "Place to be". Many discoveries await you in the Land of the Rising Sun.

By Ruth Shiraishi

